

Ethical and Sectarian Conflicts in Karachi

Background

Karachi has always been a city that welcomes people from various castes and creeds. As Pakistan's largest business hub, it attracts individuals from across the country in search of job opportunities. This diversity, however, sometimes poses challenges to the nation's ethical and social dynamics. Karachi is home to Muhajirs, Balochi, Sindhi, Punjabis, Saraiki, Balti, Pashtuns, and others. Additionally, the city reflects religious diversity, with the majority being Sunni Muslims, followed by Shias as the second-largest group, along with Christians, Hindus, Sikhs, and other communities.

Since the very beginning of this city's history we have witnessed violence and conflicts among the people. Either we talk about the great liyari gang war, or the 2009 blast on Ashura Procession. We saw violence against muhajirs, Sindhi, pathans and every other person who have ever lived in the city of will live here. "As many as 4,000 Shia (a Muslim minority group) are estimated to have been killed in sectarian attacks in Pakistan between 1987 and 2007, and thousands more Shia have been killed by Salafi extremists from 2008 to 2014^[1]". Religious differences have similarly contributed to conflicts in Karachi. The city has witnessed sectarian violence between Sunni and Shia Muslims, with periodic escalations triggered by political and external influences. Minority religious communities, such as Christians, Hindus, and Sikhs, face systemic discrimination and social exclusion, further complicating Karachi's ethical landscape.

Among those blamed for the sectarian violence in the country are mainly Deobandi militant groups, such as the Sipah-e-Sahaba Pakistan (SSP), Lashkar-e-Jhangvi (LeJ), the Tehrik-i-Taliban Pakistan (TTP), and also the Jundallah (an affiliate of the Islamic State of Iraq and the Levant). Tehrik-i-Taliban Pakistan "has claimed responsibility for most of the attacks" on Shia according to Human Rights Watch^[1]. "Karachi bus massacre: attack on Ismailis" where dozens of people were killed by gunmen on their bus. Countless tragic events happened in this city, thousands of people died, never ever any authority came to face to deal with such issues, and why is that so? Are they the one doing it?

Research Objectives

1. To examine the influence of political and media entities in alleviating tensions amongst the people.
2. How much effectively authorities are taking part to avoid future conflicts?
3. What strategies can be implemented to promote unity amongst all minorities?

Karachi has struggled with violence for years, till today, minorities often face crime and acts of terrorism. The city has always been targeted by political and social tensions, creating fear and unrest among its people. While it's hard to say these challenges won't arise again, my research will focus on understanding the root causes of unethical and sectarian conflicts to find ways to address them and create a path toward a more peaceful future for Karachi. No matter how much the peace talks happen there would always be tensions amongst the minorities, but they could be done in much better ways. There is a constant questioning of the role of government and

authorities regarding the conflict in Karachi and their absence at critical times that contributes to the growth of violence. This research will delve into the possible connections between institutional inaction and the persistence of violence, discussing why they are unable to intervene and exploring the systemic factors behind such limitations. As proposed by many researchers, the only solution to ethical violence and criminal activities is political negotiation leading to a culture of representative politics.

BIBLIOGRAPHY:

1. Wikipedia contributors. (n.d.). *Sectarian violence in Pakistan*, from https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Sectarian_violence_in_Pakistan
Violence has decreased in some areas, sectarian tensions remain prevalent. Structural reforms in education, law enforcement, and political accountability are needed to address the issue comprehensively. This article discusses the longstanding issue of conflict between various sectarian groups in the country. This violence primarily involves Sunni and Shia Muslim communities but can also include other minority groups. We can understand the social and political dynamics amongst these two groups from this article. The article also refers to other researches which include studies on all the violence that had happened in the past.
2. GAZDAR, H. (2011). Karachi Battles. *Economic and Political Weekly*, 46(38), 19–21. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/23047326>
Political and ethnic violence in Karachi has become a prominent feature of Pakistan's civil war, along with the jihadist insurgency and the nationalist uprising in Baluchistan. Negotiations among political parties stand to lose a lot from this form of violence and could, in principle, bring an end to it. According to the writer the main cause of violence and conflicts in Karachi are the extremist groups and dirty politics. Through this article we know the reason behind evolution of these conflicts.
3. Ahmed, F. (1996). Pakistan: Ethnic Fragmentation or National Integration? *The Pakistan Development Review*, 35(4), 631–645. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/41259987>.
The writer mainly discusses about the major causes of ethical conflicts and integrity in Pakistan. Major elements like sovereignty, Inter-province migration, language and culture, etc. cause issues among the people living at one place. According to Feroz Ahmed, this issue is not only in Karachi, but faced by many regions across the country. Moreover, writer also shares the trends that are affecting the ethical and cultural changes. Economics, Demographic change, and other factors are key features of this text.
4. International Crisis Group. (2007). MAPPING KARACHI'S CENTRES OF EXTREMISM. In *PAKISTAN: KARACHI'S MADRASAS AND VIOLENT EXTREMISM* (p. Page 3-Page 6). International Crisis Group. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/resrep38329.5>
This report by the International Crisis Group examines the role of Karachi's madrasas in fostering violent extremism. It maps key madrasa locations and their connection to radical ideologies, shedding light on the city's role in the broader issue of extremism in Pakistan. The report highlights the challenges of addressing extremism through educational reforms and law enforcement. This source can be valuable in understanding the socio-political factors that

contribute to extremism in urban settings such as Karachi, with implications for national security.

5. Sinha, A. (1978). Shia-Sunni Conflict. *Economic and Political Weekly*, 13(45), 1841–1842. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/4367078>

The differentiation between Shia and Sunni Muslims arises from several factors, some of which are highlighted in the article. While the article does not condone violence, it suggests that the conflicts between these two communities could potentially be resolved. This text shows how the small conflicts turn into disaster for the city, at several occasions extremist groups martyred hundreds of people which cause tension amongst communities.

6. International Crisis Group. (2022, September). *Pakistan: Sectarian violence* (Report No. 327).

Retrieved from <https://www.crisisgroup.org/sites/default/files/2022-09/327%20Pakistan%20-%20Sectarian%20Violence%20-%20Print.pdf>

This report analyses the various genres of sectarian conflicts in Karachi and digs into the deep reasons behind their existence. It provides rich insights into the nature of these conflicts, their historical background, and the factors that bring about these conflicts. This report is highly relevant to my research as it works as an invaluable resource in understanding sectarian violence. This opportunity allows for a more comprehensive exploration of the causes of these conflicts, facilitates an analysis of how they were orchestrated, and allows for the consideration of strategies to prevent similar incidents in the future. Using the findings from this report, one can develop a broader perspective on effectively managing and resolving sectarian issues.

REFERENCES:

- [1]: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Sectarian_violence_in_Pakistan

